of the People's Republic of China. China decided to take a 'soft' public approach in India. Tactically, therefore, in their public pronouncements, the Chinese engaged in soft double-speak. The official position articulated by their spokespersons said: 'The Chinese side believes all countries can launch cooperation for peaceful uses of nuclear energy while abiding by respective international obligations. At the same time, such cooperation should be conducive to upholding and strengthening the principles and effectiveness of the principle of international nuclear non-proliferation.' [8]

Such pronouncements left enough room for optimism in India about China's reasonableness, and also preserved China's positive image in Indian public opinion, which was expecting China to openly oppose India's application to the NSG. Few Indians read between the lines or cared to understand that the thrust of the Chinese position was that India's adherence to the NPT should be a pre-condition for any relaxation in NSG guidelines for India. This soft public approach was combined with evasive replies whenever Indian representatives raised the NSG issue with Chinese counterparts. This issue was raised on more than one occasion by both the then External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee and National Security Advisor M.K. Narayanan. [9] The Chinese would invariably respond by showing 'understanding' for India's position but always with the caveat that all nuclear-related activity should be within the framework of international obligations. Chinese counterparts never referred directly to the NPT or the CTBT in these conversations. This is a typical Chinese negotiating tactic that is designed to generate hope in the opposite interlocutor that the door for further discussion remains open, without disclosing the specific Chinese position.

It is also ambiguous enough for China to go either way, depending on how the matter unfolds. In the meantime, China